China to prevent competition in its neighbourhood and increase its comparative power vis-à-vis Russia, Japan, India, South Korea, Vietnam, and Indonesia. It is for China's leaders to ponder and decide whether they want to follow the well-trodden path of erstwhile great powers or wish to break new ground in international relations, as they did in transforming China economically. There is an essential contradiction between China's military assertiveness and its quest for rebalancing its economy. Should China choose the path towards regional hegemony, there is danger of China over-extending itself and incentivising countries threatened by it to band together, eventually imperilling Chinese prosperity.

Having found that the United States is not going to treat China as an equal and allow it the freedom to dominate East Asia or the Asia-Pacific, and that the US rebalance to Asia has bipartisan support in the United States,[51] China is struggling to recalibrate its geopolitical response. In this, there is the obvious attraction of weaning India away from the United States. However, the Chinese leadership, now as in the past, might erroneously assume India to be incapable of independent thinking and decision-making. In popular accounts in China, India continues to be viewed, as it was in the 1950s, as a camp follower of the West.

Due to the continuous rise in China's share of international commerce, much of which goes through the Indian Ocean, China's flag, like that of the other trading nations in the past, naturally follows its trade. Consequently, the Chinese presence in the Indian Ocean is increasing steadily, as evidenced by growing number of submarine deployments by the People's Liberation Army-Navy (PLAN), the acquisition of a military base in Djibouti, and the 99-year lease of Sri Lanka's Hambantota port.[52] The current economic relationship between India and China is unbalanced and unsustainable. China looks to partner India on its own terms while enlisting Indian support for its emblematic and imaginative project, the BRI. Such endorsement from a major